FARIA · 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · A LESSON FOR JEFF FRANZEN

Jos. A. Bank: an American clothier, not Joseph Banks

The name looks like the botanist and is not him. Jos. is an abbreviation of Joseph. Bank, on the shop signs, has no final s. Sir Joseph Banks sailed with Cook and is the subject of another lesson on this day. This page is a clothing company in Baltimore.

The usual founding date is 1905, with a family workshop behind it. Charles Bank, a Lithuanian immigrant, was a tailor. His grandson Joseph worked young, as a cloth cutter and a salesman. A family trade, a formal company, and a brand name are three dates. Do not collapse them into one man who did everything in one year. Sources even disagree about the grandson's middle name, so this lesson uses Joseph and does not pretend to settle it.

Joseph married Anna Hartz, of a Baltimore clothing family. The partnership called L. Hartz & Bank belongs to those early years. Published accounts put it in 1912 or in 1922. Both years are in print, so this page will not pick one it cannot defend. In 1945 Joseph and his son Howard bought the Hartz share. The brand Jos. A. Bank is the name from that change of ownership.

Shops of their own came in the 1950s, a catalog around 1960. There were 11 stores when Quaker Oats bought the firm in 1981. A leveraged buyout in 1986 left a heavy debt and a near failure, then a recovery and a public sale of shares in 1994.

On 18 June 2014 Men's Wearhouse completed the purchase at 65 dollars a share, about 1.8 billion dollars, after the two companies had tried to buy each other in 2013. It was not a sale to Brooks Brothers in 2011. The parent company took the name Tailored Brands in 2016. In 2020 that parent went through Chapter 11 and emerged as a private company on 1 December. The brand still sells clothes. A current store count is easy to invent and is left out.

No British chain named for the botanist turned up in the records checked for this lesson. Not finding a chain is not a proof that none ever existed. It is a reason not to tell that story. The Chicago firm Hart Schaffner & Marx, next, is another similar name with no documented tie to these Hartzes.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Encyclopedia.com, Jos. A. Bank Clothiers: https://www.encyclopedia.com/books/politics-and-business-magazines/jos-bank-clothiers-inc
- Tailored Brands, 18 June 2014, on the Men's Wearhouse acquisition: https://www.tailoredbrands.com/2014/06/18/mens-wearhouse-completes-acquisition-of-jos-a-bank/

- Tailored Brands, 1 December 2020, on emerging from restructuring: https://www.tailoredbrands.com/2020/12/01/tailored-brands-successfully-completes-financial-restructuring/

Key facts

- Jos. A. Bank is a Baltimore clothier. Joseph Banks the botanist is a different person. The spellings differ.
- The firm is dated from 1905, with earlier family work. Charles Bank was the immigrant tailor. Joseph, his grandson, was the young cutter. Do not force one sole founder.
- In 1945 Joseph and Howard bought the Hartz interest. The 1912 and 1922 partnership dates conflict, so neither is asserted here.
- Men's Wearhouse bought the company on 18 June 2014 for about 1.8 billion dollars. Not Brooks Brothers in 2011. Tailored Brands emerged from Chapter 11 on 1 December 2020.